call to pledge strict adherence to the SCO charter on “Long-Term Neighbourliness, Friendship and Cooperation” would aim to bind India and Pakistan to the “Shanghai Spirit” through a five-year action plan that runs until 2022.[34]

There is little prospect of the SCO breaking the Sino–Pakistani strategic nexus, but Beijing as well as Moscow both seem eager to make the organisation a pivot for closer India–Pakistan entente.[35] Both capitals know that the broad-based diplomatic and security interactions at various levels within the SCO framework could bring about a positive change in the regional climate. For instance, in May 2018, Beijing hosted the conference of SCO’s Security Council Secretaries, where President Xi received top Indian and Pakistani security officials.[36] The same month, Pakistan hosted the SCO-RATS Dialogue of legal experts in Islamabad to discuss ways and mean of tackling terror.[37] This proved to be the first litmus test for Xi’s diplomacy, as it meant getting officials from India and Pakistan in the same room to discuss terrorism.

Moscow hosted the military drills of the SCO Peace Mission 2018 in the Urals, where troops from both India and Pakistan participated. Also in 2019, amid tension along the volatile Line of Control in Jammu and Kashmir, Russia, China, and India held joint anti-terrorism exercises with Pakistan and four Central Asian republics on Russian territory under the umbrella of the SCO, with nearly 130,000 troops taking part in the drills.[38]

Russia’s recent shift of policy towards Pakistan has been a nuanced one, with Moscow playing a balancing game without sacrificing its ties with its traditional partner India. Given Russia’s continuing standoff with the West, a closer tieup with Islamabad adds to Russian foreign policy options. Also, Russia seems unwilling to leave Pakistan entirely to China and has been making efforts to extend its own influence over Islamabad. However, Moscow may not have